SOCIAL MEDIA ANALYSIS
FLORIDA UNIVERSITIES

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2026

PROJECT GOALS & SUCCESS METRICS

1.

PROJECT GOALS

Analyze social media performance across 12 Florida universities by tracking engagement, posting activity, and growth. The goal is to compare universities, identify top performers, and understand what content and strategies lead to better results.

2.

SUCCESS METRICS

Measure performance using engagement rate (likes, comments, shares), follower growth, and posting frequency. These metrics help determine which universities perform best and which platforms generate the most engagement.

3.

TRACKING & TIMELINE

Data is collected twice per week over a 7-week period using LinkedIn and Instagram. Weekly tracking allows us to identify trends, compare performance over time, and generate final data-driven insights.

THE 12 UNIVERSITIES

- Florida State University
- University of Florida
- University of Miami
- University of Central Florida

BRUNA

- Florida International University
- Florida Atlantic University
- Florida Gulf Coast University
- Stetson University

JACKSON

- Nova Southeastern University
- Florida Agricultural and Mechanical University
- Florida Institute of Technology
- Bethune-Cookman University

KEVIN

PLATFORMS TRACKED

- LinkedIn
- Instagram
- All universities confirmed active
- Focus on consistent comparison

WHY THESE SCHOOLS?

- Mix of public + private universities
- Different sizes, rankings, and engagement levels
- Strong comparison group for FSU

THE 12

METHODOLOGY & TRACKING RULES

TRACKING METHODOLOGY

- Data collected twice per week (Wed & Sun @ 6PM)
- Each member tracks 4 universities
- Data recorded in shared Google Sheet
- Weekly review to identify trends + top performers

TRACKING RULES

- Track ONLY original posts (not reposts)
- Sum total engagement (no estimating)
- Do NOT round numbers
- Enter 0 if no posts
- Use laptop/desktop only
- Double-check all data before submission

PROJECT GOAL OUTCOME

- Which university grew the fastest?
- Which platform performs best?
- Does posting more increase engagement?
- What content performs best?

WEEK 1 & 2 HIGHLIGHTS

Top 3:

TOP 2

2.31% (WK1)
1.31% (WK2)

FLORIDA A&M

Led LinkedIn both weeks; strong across both platforms.

TOP 1

18.87% (WK1)
8.71% (WK2)

FGCU

Consistent leader, viral basketball content

TOP 3

9.56% (WK1)
9.34% (WK2)

STETSON

Punched way above its weight; NSU pushed them out Wk2

Key Insights:

- Instagram generated 6x more engagement than LinkedIn across the board.
- UF posted zero content on Sunday of Week 1 and was completely inactive Week 2, biggest university, lowest activity.
- University of Miami had the highest raw engagement volume, every post exceeded 1,000 likes, meme content drove it.
- Spring semester energy was high, homecoming posts, basketball, and school spirit content performed best.

WEEK 3 & 4 HIGHLIGHTS

Top 3:

TOP 2

11.60% (WK1)
16.34% (WK2)
NOVA SOUTHEASTERN

Instagram driven entirely by basketball championships and swim team national title

TOP 1

23.59%
FLORIDA A&M

Instagram engagement in Week 4 (highest rate in the entire study), also driven by Academy Awards viral moment in Week 3

TOP 3

36,169 ENGAGEMENTS
UM

Week 4 Sunday, consistently dominant in raw numbers

Key Insights:

- Spring break visibly killed posting, Week 3 had the lowest LinkedIn total (3,225 engagements vs 19,094 in Week 1), FSU and UF both posted zero content multiple checkpoints
- FAMU's Week 4 Instagram spike (34,505 engagements, 23.59%) was the single highest engagement rate in the entire 7-week study
- NSU proved that event-driven content spikes fast but doesn't sustain, their peak was championships week, then dropped sharply
- UCF has 498K+ LinkedIn followers but consistently under 0.1% engagement, follower count ≠ engagement

WEEK 5 & 6 HIGHLIGHTS

Top 3:

TOP 2

12.52% (WK6 WED)
9.25% (WK5 SUN)
BETHUNE COOKMAN

the biggest surprise of the study

TOP 1

33,719 ENGAGEMENTS
UM

(Week 6 Wednesday), dominant raw performer every single week

TOP 3

9.06% (WK6 SUN)
FGCU

consistent top performer across all 6 weeks on both platforms

Key Insights:

- Bethune Cookman emerged as a consistent overperformer, with the smallest follower base (~26K IG) but regularly top-3 in engagement rate
- UF finally returned to LinkedIn posting in Week 5 with their best LI performance (0.29%), then went silent again Sunday inconsistency remains their story
- UCF had a breakout Instagram Sunday in Week 6 (12,731 engagements, 8.07%), their best week of the study
- The Instagram vs LinkedIn gap widened further universities generating 10–20x more engagement per follower on Instagram

WEEK 7 HIGHLIGHTS

Top 3:

TOP 2

29.34% (WKD **BETHUNE COOKMAN**

Instagram on Wednesday, highest Wednesday rate in the study

TOP 1

32.97% **FIU**

Instagram engagement rate, 57,588 engagements on Sunday, the single highest engagement count in the entire study

TOP 3

9.36% **FAU**

Instagram Sunday, their best week; showed strong late-study improvement

Key Insights:

- FIU's 57,588 Sunday engagements iis the record for the entire project likely likely a viral or major event post
- BCU's 29.34% is extraordinary for any institution, 3 posts, 7,660 engagements from just ~26K followers
- UF gained +637 Instagram followers on Sunday without posting a single piece of content, passive growth from tagging/mentions
- FGCU was a top-3 finisher on LinkedIn Sunday (0.83%) the most consistent dual-platform performer across all 7 weeks
- Overall study winner by engagement rate: Instagram universally; by raw volume: University of Miami; by consistency: FGCU

KEY TRENDS ACROSS 7 WEEKS

1. **PLATFORM WINNER: INSTAGRAM ENGAGEMENT**

   Instagram generated 5-20x more engagement per follower than LinkedIn, showcasing its power in building an active university community across all weeks.
   Passive vs. Active: LinkedIn followers remained passive, while Instagram encouraged vibrant interactions, proving to be the superior platform for engagement among univerisities.

2. **POSTING MORE DOES NOY EQUAL ENGAGEMENT**

   Quality over Quantity: Engagement thrives on quality content rather than sheer volume of posts. Universities should focus on crafting compelling messages.
   Meaningful interactions: Fostering genuine connections with followers is essential. Engaging storytelling and relatable content encourage deeper engagement compared to frequent but superficial updates.

3. **FOLLOWERS COUNT IS OVERRATED**

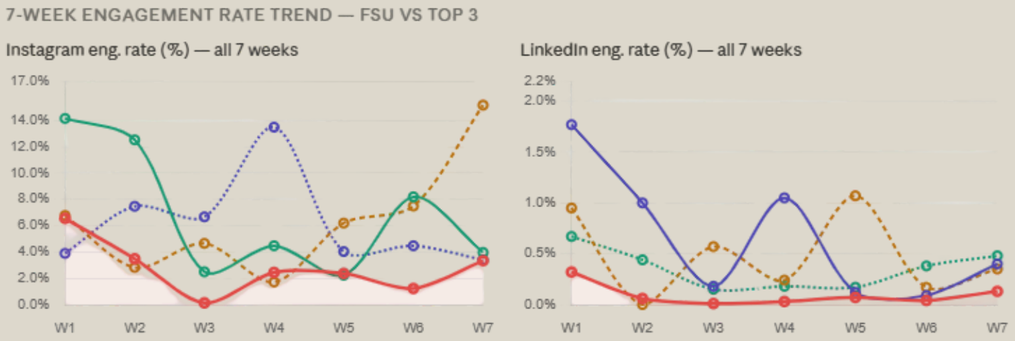
   UF boasts 650k LinkedIn followers, but engagement rates lag at under 0.1%. In contrast, Bethune Cookman, with 23k followers, achieved an impressive 1.8% rate on LinkedIn and 29.34% on Instagram in Week 7

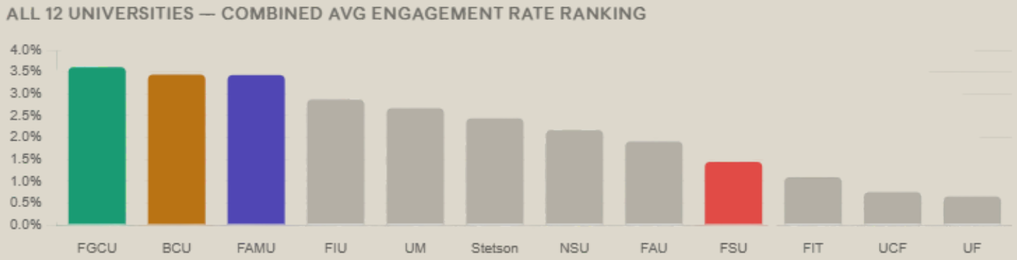
4. **ENGAGEMENT RATES MATTER MOST**

   Universities must prioritize strategies that enhance engagement over sheer follower numbers.

FSU VS. PEER UNIVERSITIES

FSU demonstrates a strong social media presence with significant followings on platforms. Despite having one of the largest audiences among peer universities, FSU faces challenges in engagement rates.





#1 overall

Florida Gulf Coast University

IG avg eng. rate	6.86%
LI avg eng. rate	0.35%
Combined eng. rate	3.61%
Total engagement	77,269
TImes ranked #1	6/28
Zero-post checkpoints	0

#2 overall

Bethune Cookman

IG avg eng. rate	6.40%
LI avg eng. rate	0.48%
Combined eng. rate	3.44%
Total engagement	24,886
TImes ranked #1	7/28
Zero-post checkpoints	2

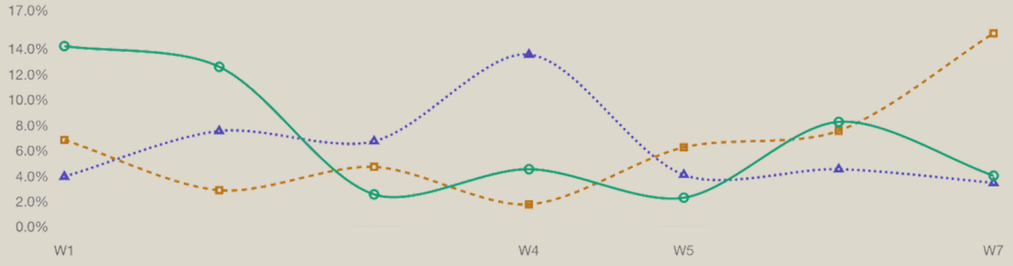
#3 overall

Florida A&M University

IG avg eng. rate	6.20%
LI avg eng. rate	0.66%
Combined eng. rate	3.43%
Total engagement	135,283
TImes ranked #1	8/28
Zero-post checkpoints	0

TOP 3 ON INSTAGRAM

- FGCU is the most consistent Instagram performer, it ranked #1 four times and had the highest average rate (6.86%), but its week-by-week numbers swing a lot (std dev 5.31%), meaning its performance is tied to specific content moments rather than a stable strategy.
- Bethune Cookman is the wildcard. Its median rate is only 3.21% but its average is 6.40%, a huge gap because it had two explosive spikes: 15.16% in Week 7 and a single-checkpoint peak of 29.34%, the highest rate recorded in the entire study.
- FAMU is the volume leader, 115 total Instagram posts, averaging 8.2 per checkpoint. Its peak was 23.59% in Week 4, likely driven by cultural content (Oscars, HBCU identity).



#1 Instagram

Florida Gulf Coast University

Avg engagement rate	6.86%
Peak week	14.15% (Wk1)
Peak engagement	14,306
Avg posts/check	5.5

#2 Instagram

Bethune Cookman

Avg engagement rate	6.40%
Peak week	15.16% (Wk7)
Peak engagement	7,660
Avg posts/check	2.7

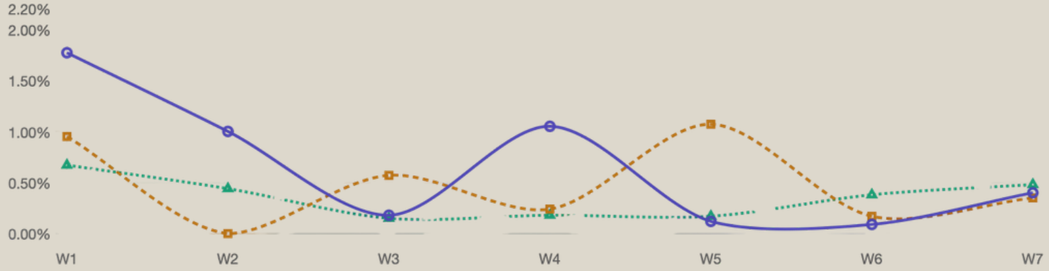
#3 Instagram

Florida A&M University

Avg engagement rate	6.20%
Peak week	13.49% (Wk4)
Peak engagement	34,505
Avg posts/check	8.2

TOP 3 ON LINKEDIN

- FAMU dominates LinkedIn, it ranked #1 in 7 out of 14 checkpoints. More posts strongly correlate with better results for FAMU on LinkedIn (correlation: 0.76).
- Bethune Cookman is remarkable on LinkedIn given its tiny follower base (~23K). It ranked #1 three times and hit 1.80% in Week 5.
- FGCU is steady but unspectacular on LinkedIn, the most consistent of the three (std dev only 0.27%) but never a top performer.



#1 LinkedIn

Florida A&M University

Avg engagement rate	0.66%
Peak week	1.77% (Wk1)
Peak engagement	2,089
Avg posts/check	4.1

#2 LinkedIn

Bethune Cookman

Avg engagement rate	0.48%
Peak week	1.07% (Wk5)
Peak engagement	427
Avg posts/check	1.6

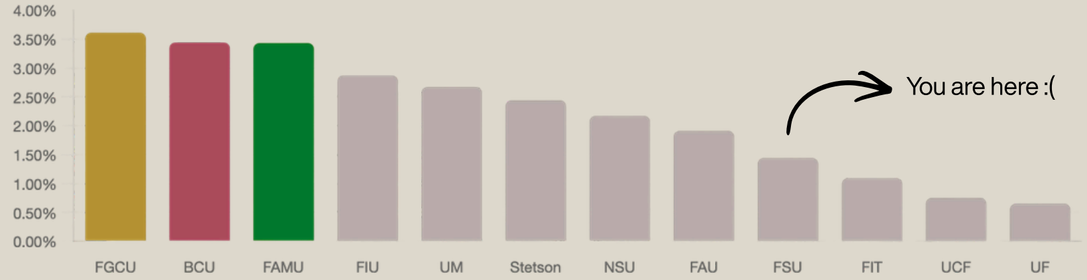
#3 LinkedIn

Florida Gulf Coast University

Avg engagement rate	0.35%
Peak week	0.67% (Wk1)
Peak engagement	724
Avg posts/check	4.3

TOP 3 OVERALL

- The most important finding is that FAMU ranked #1 across all checkpoints more than anyone else, 8 times out of 28 total checkpoints. No other school comes close on that consistency metric.
- Bethune Cookman is the most efficient school in the study, 61 total posts generated 24,886 engagements. That's about 408 engagements per post on average. FAMU gets about 786 per post but posts 172 times. The story is: Bethune Cookman does more with less.
- FGCU's strong posting-to-engagement correlation on both platforms (0.83 IG, 0.73 LI) suggests a simple, actionable recommendation for them: just post more, and results follow. The other two schools require more strategic thinking about content type and timing.



#1 overall

Florida Gulf Coast University

Combined average	3.61%
Total engagement	77,269,
Total follower growth	+2,251
Platforms in top 3	IG #1 LI #3

#2 overall

Bethune Cookman

Combined average	3.44%
Total engagement	24,886
Total follower growth	+529
Platforms in top 3	IG #2 LI #2

#3 overall

Florida A&M University

Combined average	3.43%
Total engagement	135,283
Total follower growth	+2,279
Platforms in top 3	IG #3 LI #1

CHALLENGES & DATA NOTES

11

Zero-post checkpoints (University of Florida)

22

Rounded Instagram follower counts (Week 1 - 3)

13

Negative follower growth instances across all schools

179

Tracker notes logged across all 377 data rows

5

University with hidden Instagram comments at some point

Instagram Limitation

Follower counts were rounded in Weeks 1-3: Instagram only displays rounded figures (e.g., 357K) unless you hover over the count on desktop. The team discovered the precise method mid-study. 22 entries across Weeks 1–3 use estimated follower counts, slightly affecting engagement rate calculations for those weeks.

Hidden likes & comments on Instagram: Instagram allows accounts to hide likes and comments on individual posts. 5 universities (including FSU and NSU) had zero-comment checkpoints because of this. Engagement totals for these schools are understated. the true numbers are higher than what was recorded.

Data consistency

Since Week 1 was our first checkpoint, there was no previous data to calculate follower growth. To avoid leaving the field blank, we used the current follower count as both the starting and ending value, resulting in a growth of zero for all universities in Week 1. This only affects the first checkpoint; from Week 2 onward, growth is calculated normally against the prior checkpoint's recorded count.

The data is solid for trend analysis and relative comparison, but three caveats apply to every claim

(1) engagement rates favor smaller schools by design, so always pair rate with raw engagement numbers

(2) weeks 1–3 Instagram follower counts have minor rounding errors that slightly affect early engagement rate calculations

(3) universities with hidden comments or zero-post weeks are likely underperforming their true engagement, UF in particular may be a much stronger performer than the data suggests.

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR FSU

(WHAT THE DATA SAYS TO DO NEXT)

0/28

Times FSU ranked #1 in any checkpoint

0.09%

FSU avg LinkedIn eng. rate (2nd lowest of 12 schools)

15.9

Avg LI posts per checkpoint, yet only 102 total comments all study

-0.07

FSU LinkedIn posts vs eng. rate correlation (more posts = LESS engagement)

10.50%

FSU's best IG rate ever — proof the audience can be activated

Instagram recommendations:
Re-enables likes & comments on posts: FSU has comments turned off on most Instagram posts, confirmed by the tracker in Week 2. This directly suppresses engagement scores and makes the algorithm treat posts as low-performing.
Lean into content that already works: The data shows FSU's highest-performing IG content consistently falls into three categories: campus nostalgia ("Then → Now" post, Week 7: 4.95%), sports wins (nolebaseball post: 5K+ likes, Week 5), and alumni stories (Josh Williamson at Winter Olympics, Week 2).
Maintain posting during low-activity weeks: Week 3 (spring break) saw FSU post just 0.5 times per checkpoint and crash to a 0.13% IG rate, the lowest of the entire study. Top performers FGCU and FAMU never hit zero posts in any checkpoint.

LinkedIn recommendations:
Stop mass-posting (quality over volume): FSU averages 15.9 LinkedIn posts per checkpoint, the highest of any school, yet generates one of the lowest engagement rates (0.09%). More posts are actively hurting FSU's LinkedIn performance.
Shift from reposts to original storytelling: Trackers flagged repeatedly that FSU's LinkedIn feed is dominated by reposts, especially from the FSU Division of Research and College of Education. Reposts don't count toward engagement and signal low originality to the algorithm.
Target professional milestones & student wins: The tracker noted that FSU's "FSU Student Stars" series (Week 6) and the ACC InVenture Prize student win (Week 7) were among the best-performing LI posts. Content celebrating student and faculty achievements resonates with LinkedIn's professional audience.

FSU doesn't have an audience problem, it has an activation problem. With 248K Instagram and 429K LinkedIn followers, the reach is already there. The data points to three quick wins:
1. Turn comments back on Instagram,
2. Post less but better on LinkedIn
3. Replicate the emotional content formula that already worked, campus nostalgia, sports wins, and alumni stories. If FSU had maintained its Week 1 strategy across all 7 weeks, it would likely be in the top 3.

THANK YOU

APRIL 2026